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Anne Phillips

Anne Phillips has led a distinguished career as a pianist, vocalist, composer, and a much-in-demand producer of television commercials. Together with her husband Bob Kindred, she composed and directed an iconic holiday production entitled "Bending Towards the Light" which has featured prominent jazz musicians in leading roles.

Anne was interviewed via Zoom on February 24, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Anne Phillips with me today. And I won't do a complete introduction because that would take too long. So I'll say vocalist, composer, producer, and a general survivor of the music business.

AP: Yes.

MR: Does that sound all right?

AP: Yes indeed.

MR: What makes the music business something that you describe as being a survivor of?

AP: Well let's see — I know too many people who haven't survived. I was very fortunate because I played piano. I could play piano and sing. And so when I came to New York I didn't have to wait tables. I've done nothing in my life but music. And then the music business began, which is first playing in clubs, some lovely ones. Like I played actually opposite Bobby Short in his first gig at the — it wasn't the Carlyle then it was the Beverly Hotel, and I was the other, the off piano. And I sat there writing names of songs and lyrics down, things I'd never heard. And then I found out about demos for songwriters, and it was a wonderful time. There were the older songwriters and there were the new kids coming in like Carole King and Gerry Goffin and Ellie Greenwich and Neil Sedaka, all those people. And there was a little studio that did most of them, Associated, and some of us who have survived the whole thing say we ought to call it "Associated University" because we learned everything there.

MR: Would you say that music chose you as opposed to the other way around?

AP: Yeah. I had no way I would be doing anything. My parents were not in show business. I was — actually I'm from Wyomissing, Pennsylvania. Do you recognize that word? Well if you look up Taylor Swift you'll find out that's where she's from.

MR: Wow. You have a connection there.

AP: Not really.

MR: Well do you recall any — nowadays I would use the word "epiphany." Back then it might have like AHA!, like an AHA! moment either from recordings or the radio or just something that really reached inside and grabbed you at a young age?

AP: I was always waiting for the next song that was going to be popular, and that's when they were songs. Like "Slow Boat to China." Things like that coming in on the radio, and I'd just sit down and play it because I could play by ear, I read music too, but I could play most of what I heard.

MR: Did you hear bass notes? That sounds like a silly question but when I learn a song off a recording or something, the first thing I do is try to figure out the bass notes.

AP: Yeah. But I didn't think of them because I didn't even know the word, but I did hear harmony. And don't ask me how, that's just a gift that I have that I cannot explain.

MR: When you got into doing this work in clubs singing and playing, I've done a bit of that, and you can tell when people are coming up to the piano to make a request and you know you sort of cross your fingers, you try to keep playing with your fingers crossed. Did you have occasion, because in the mid- to late-'50s rock & roll was starting to make the airwaves and I wondered if you got requests in that genre that you had to like — oh I'm thinking of like Kay Starr "The Rock & Roll Waltz," things that were changing from the swing era.

AP: Yes. Well what was her big hit, because I couldn't believe it when I heard her. She came in, well I mean this is years later, to — was it Condon's that had this afternoon or early evening thing, and Kay Starr came in and I thought oh Wheel of Fortune. No, she was a heck of a jazz singer. And of course there were a lot of those like Rosemary Clooney and Patti Page, who were really good singers but then they had to sing the stuff that was coming in now. And Mitch Miller — we all know about him.

MR: Oh right. And "How Much is that Doggie in the Window" etcetera.

AP: Right.

MR: Well how did you deal with that? Did you make notes, like learn this for tomorrow, learn this for next week?

AP: Nobody ever asked me for that stuff. The clubs I was playing in only wanted to hear the standards and that's all.

MR: The Great American Songbook type?

AP: That's what you call it now.

MR: Yes.

AP: It was just songs then.

MR: Oh, okay. That's — I want to know about that. I've always wondered, when was that phrase sort of invented. It probably wasn't invented by the musicians either. Usually the phrases are not.

AP: It's a funny thing you asked that because I called it The American Song. Or — and then they called it The Great American Songbook and I said oh somebody must've heard me talking because that's the way it is now. And now it's gone into its own slot in the records — not the record store, there are none of those.

MR: Well you've partly addressed this question but nowadays and for the last number of decades we've had much access to a great deal of material, first through printed fake books and now everything is online, you can get the chords on your phone and so forth. What did you do back then to learn these songs?

AP: Well the piano teacher I had, after Miss Angstadt — who wouldn't let me play anything but I did learn to read music and that's good. But nevertheless when I was a senior in high school the piano teacher I had said, "I can get you a fake book. They're illegal but I can get you one for $25 and this is what you should have." So I still have my old first edition. And do you know where they came from?

MR: I do not.

AP: Oh, well there used to be a service that would send to club date musicians — what we call club date musicians now — all the latest songs. And they were little cards like this and they had the melody and the lyrics and the chords. And somebody, I have no idea who, put them together three to a page. And that became the first fake book. And they were illegal because nobody was getting paid. None of the writers were getting paid for printing these. And so I have one and my first husband had one too, so I have two old fake books and you can find anything you know.

MR: I wonder how you would have felt if you wrote a song and it showed up in these fake books where no one was getting any royalties etcetera.

AP: Yeah. Well who's getting what today anyhow when they can get a penny for something that got played in Portugal.

MR: That's true. Do you remember any of your best and worst solo piano gigs over the years? That's always a tough question, but I'm thinking of you at that time and you were playing multiple places and what's the worst thing that ever happened on a gig?

AP: Well I think taking the bus from the Port Authority to Wallingford, New Jersey to play at the Wishing Well or the Elbow Room, and then taking the bus back. I mean those gigs were from nine to three or ten to four in the morning. And I did that. And it was just me, I didn't have a bass player or anything. It was just me. And when I think of that now, oh my God. And I came through it unscathed. I don't know how.

MR: Did your parents know you were doing that?

AP: They didn't. No I called my mother one time and I said, "Oh yes I'm playing in a place that's on Broadway" and she went [gasps]. And I said, "In Passaic, New Jersey." So they had no idea really what that was all about.

MR: There's a phrase that I recall from music school and the group of us who wanted to "make it" in the music business.

AP: Um hum.

MR: And at the time I'm not sure we even had a notion of what that was. Some of us wanted — you know like I wanted to play with Blood, Sweat & Tears or that kind of thing. And do you recall at that time setting goals? And what did "make it" mean for you?

AP: No. I'll tell you where I first heard jazz and this is kind of interesting. My sister, two years younger, was a fine artist and she could draw. And so Wyomissing is outside of Reading, PA. So whoever was coming into town in Reading she would do a portrait of, and then she would go and get it signed. Anyway I happened to love Doodles Weaver. Do you remember Doodles Weaver?

MR: The cartoon?

AP: No. Doodles Weaver was the singer with Spike Jones. [sings] Oh "Beetle Bomb"? — and so forth, and "Horse Race" and so forth.

MR: Indeed. [sings] In some secluded rendezvous.

AP: Yes exactly. Well I didn't know anything about jazz but I knew there had to be something more than Dixieland because I heard people talking about it in high school. But anyway, so I took my sister out to get Doodles' signed. And it was in this lovely country hotel and there was a guy playing piano who was a local piano player, and so they were very nice to us little girls and he signed his picture. And he said, "What do you want to do when you grow up?" I said well singing. He said, "Well sing something." So I did. Well the next thing I know I got a call from a guy, Ron Kalina who lived in Reading and had a five voice vocal group and was looking for a girl to sing second. And so, as a senior in high school that was when I realized where I belonged because twice a week I would drive into his row house in Reading and do these hip arrangements. Did you ever hear of the Skylarks?

MR: Um hum.

AP: George — oh no, I can't quite remember his name — was one of the Skylarks, and he was from Reading. And Ronny wrote those kinds of hip arrangements. And so there I was every Thursday and Sunday singing with real musicians, real jazz musicians. And that was the first time I heard a Dizzy Gillespie record. "Dizzy Atmosphere." And that's when I discovered jazz. And Ron kept on going, he was a great harmonica player as well, lived in L.A. and we kept in touch somehow, in a funny way, after years after that. But that was really the start. And then I went to Oberlin and I went in the college, nobody was guiding me. But I auditioned for the big band and I got that, and then I got a weekly radio show. My maiden name is Dinsmore, so it was Dinny Dinsmore sings on WOBC Oberlin. And anyway I went there and then when I also sang — we brought in — we

formed the first jazz club because there was no jazz out there. In fact the conservatory wouldn't let us use the conservatory piano for the concert when we brought Dave Brubeck in.

MR: Right. Yeah.

AP: And that's when I met Dave and fortunately we had been in touch because I used one of his songs in the jazz nativity and he was in it and his son Chris was a king.

MR: Oh. Chris was a king. Was it "God's Love Made Visible" that you used?

AP: Yes. Yes.

MR: Yeah.

AP: I heard that in the "Fiesta de la Posada" when it was first done up in Connecticut before it had its real performance. And I just loved it. And so years later when I was writing the "Jazz Nativity" I realized that after the manger scene, what a perfect thing. So I called him and he said yes.

MR: Lovely. Let me take you back to that — you described working on demos. When you showed up to do a demo, what was usually presented to you? Was there a written out vocal line or was someone just sort of like singing it to you?

AP: Well a written lead sheet with just the chords and the melody and lyrics. And in an hour, bass, piano, drums, guitar, I'd sing the vocal and then also do a three part back-up. Finished in an hour.

MR: So that little five piece vocal ensemble paid off for you.

AP: Oh, did it ever.

MR: Hearing those harmonies.

AP: Yeah.

MR: And how much did they pay?

AP: I think it was 25 dollars maybe. Maybe it was 15 and 5 for each overdub. Because you were still going reel-to-reel.

MR: Were the musicians at that time normally able to say — I mean you could say to them, "You know this is in D, can we take it up in E flat it will sound better"? They were capable of that?

AP: Yes. Oh yeah. And usually if they had a guy singer or something that they had to put it in a different key, I have perfect pitch and so it was like having to transpose each note as I sight read it. But the musicians were incredible. Because it was, you know, after the big band era and so the people that were with big bands — Everett Barksdale — do you remember that guitar player with Art Tatum? Everett did a lot of demos. And then as it went on the newer kids, Al Gorgoni and Trade Martin, the younger kids came in because when all the music started and all of the kids from Brooklyn came in, there's a different

feel to it. And so the guitar players like Bucky and George and those people didn't have that feel. So the new young kids were playing it.

MR: You know Bucky talked about that, how some people could grab the — they call it the "straight eighth note feel" as opposed to swing. Some people could transition to it and some people couldn't or didn't want to.

AP: Absolutely right. It all changed. And actually that's how I got into doing record dates because I had — I didn't come in as a jazz person, I didn't ever listen to "Rock Around the Clock" and that stuff. But when I started doing the demos for Aldon Music mainly and Hill & Range, all of these that were the young writers and you know what the Carole King feel is, I could do that. And I didn't laugh at it as some of the older singers and musicians did. And so everything really changed. And so I really became the hottest call to get singers in record dates because I could get singers that read. There were still written parts, but could get that feel.

MR: You just said an important thing about — I translate it as it's not necessary for you to really like something in order to do a good job with it. That you don't have to love a piece of music to give it your all, and to be professional.

AP: No. But I can hardly remember pieces that I didn't like. There was one demo I did which was a sort of an oddball thing from some other studio. And I think it was Liberace's brother had a company that said, "We'll set your song to music." So people would send in lyrics and they would put them to the same damn tune that was awful. That one stands out in my mind because all the rest of them I did were for the real pros. And those who weren't pros became pros, like Little Eva you know, Eva, "Locomotion." She was Carole and Gerry's house sitter. Took care of the kids. And they were writing "Locomotion" and Eva sang it and they said, "Well let's record it with her." And that demo became a master and a big hit.

MR: I wonder if you ever had an experience where you did a demo and you said to yourself, "This is going to be a hit." You recognized it as the potential.

AP: Yeah. Some Burt Bacharach things. Because I did a lot for Burt. And I remember being at Bell Sound, there was a guy named Domenick Romeo who did all of the mastering right there. They did the mastering there. And I was walking past his room and Burt and Hal were there and they said, "Annie come in and tell us which side is a hit." And I think it was Dion. I think it was the first Dion. And I think they put it back-to-back and then had to split it because both sides were taking off.

MR: Wow. They were both A sides. Yeah.

AP: But the best thing that happened on something that wasn't one of those, I was at Dick Charles' studio. And he called me up and said, "I think there's an elderly man who's written a lot of music for the Kraft Music Hall themes and stuff, Vladimir Solinsky. And

he has some songs he's had lyrics put to and I think you're the right singer to do it. And so I did and they were beautiful but not hip type songs. They were beautiful songs. And about two months later I got a call from the studio and they said, "Call Joe Reisman over at Roulette Records, he wants to talk to you." And that's where my album, the first one, "Born to be Blue" came, because he had an idea or he had a song that he wanted to use as the title song. Actually that was "Lonelyville." And we did the whole recording and he called the most wonderful arranger, Kermit Levinsky. And there I was, 23 years old and brand new in the business, and Milt Hinton, Osie Johnson, Dick Hyman, full string section, Doc Severinsen on trumpet. And so I did that album, which is quite beautiful and it got great reviews and you know, "Watch this singer there's no comparison" and all that good stuff in *Billboard*. And then of course it was '59, '60 — rock was coming in — so there wasn't any second album. But, and this is the amazing thing that happened, about 15 years later I was doing some record dates back up in Bell South, and this young engineer caught me in the hallway and said, "Anne, I was doing inventory here and I found something you might like to have. Don't ever tell anybody who gave this to you." And he gave me a 7-1/2 copy of the record which is now "Born to be Blue." They discovered that somebody had used "Lonelyville" as a title song so they flipped it and so the B side became the A side and the first tune on that was "Born to be Blue." And that's as the years went on I found out that it was known all over, they had released it in Japan and never told me, but all over the world people knew it. And I was finally doing another album — I don't think you still call them albums anymore. And the promoter I got, Virginia Wicks, who you may have heard of. I sent "Born to be Blue" to her and said, "This is something I did years ago." And she said, "Oh my God I would love to promote that." And I said, " Well I'm on it." She said, "Who cares?" So it was pressed on a CD and it got great reviews, I mean just incredible reviews. And more people knew about it and bought it. And nobody ever knew.

MR: What a business. Speaking of writing lyrics, I'm going to read — this is an excerpt from an Anne Phillips lyric and you have to finish it. Okay? "But no matter how I have tried, this feeling inside —

AP: [sings] How I have tried, this feeling inside, can't be denied, so what if it's done — it's home. That's "Fried Bananas."

MR: That's right. You get to move on to the next round. You know when I read that about "Fried Bananas" I got out the Dexter Gordon thing and first of all I thought she's going to have the term "fried bananas" in the lyrics because of the story that went with it. Then I listened to the whole thing and it's quite clever and quite an accomplishment.

AP: You did hear the whole story of my husband saying, "I've not seen you at the piano anymore?"

MR: It was like a dare? He dared you to do it or something?

AP: Yes. Yeah. And he literally opened up a new fake book and there was "Fried" he said, "Do that before I get home." So I did. And the funny thing is I use the verse to it now. I've been doing — well on my birthday party I did this whole show and I started [sings] I was a kid/the night that I woke and cried/take me to New York City please/let's ride to New York/That was my nirvana/No more little bitty/Gone to New York City/That's all I could see/I dreamed it would be/The place that I would reside in/The place that I would call home. That that's the beginning of my telling my story.

MR: Nice. A story in song.

AP: Yup. So it really is true, my mother did hear me crying and she ran up the stairs. I must have been about 14. And I said, "All my friends have been to New York and you only take me to Philadelphia."

MR: What did — this is kind of a silly question, but do you remember what you paid for your first residence, your first apartment in New York City?

AP: Yeah I think three of us paid 50 bucks apiece, and it was a two bedroom apartment on the fifth floor. Yeah.

MR: You've come a long way.

AP: Where I live now I rented in 1977. And it went condo. And I couldn't buy it then although it was about a quarter or less of what they — it's like a 3 million dollar apartment, so I'm still living here.

MR: Name this tune. All right, let me see if I can pull this off. It starts with a rest [scats]. Shall I try it again?

AP: Yeah.

MR: We're in the commercial world. [scats]

AP: Pepsi pours it on.

MR: That's right.

AP: That's mine.

MR: Yes. I'm going to ask you to tell me a story about a jingle from start to finish, but before I forget I wanted to make an observation about that particular music that you — it goes up in one key. At one point in the middle of the long commercial it goes up in one key and it comes back down a half step up. Do you remember that?

AP: Well Pepsi goes up but it comes back, and by the time I go through the bridge it comes back down to the original key.

MR: Yes. But somehow there's this [scats] .

AP: In the bridge [scats]. And it wound up in the original key. See I'm smart.

MR: So I find that whole era pretty fascinating. I talked to people like Chico Hamilton who was in that, and Manny Albam. And the stories they tell are pretty fascinating. Can you

just briefly take me from when you first get contacted to do a product and the sequence of events that ends up with a commercial?

AP: Can I tell you two interesting stories?

MR: Sure.

AP: Okay the first one is at 5:30 Jim Jordan, who was then the president of BBD and O but he had been a copywriter, the first copywriter to rise to the presidency. And I was doing a lot of stuff for him. And it was about 5:30 at night and I'm making dinner for the kids. And he says, "Anne, listen, the Sheraton account is in Boston but they haven't been able to do this. It's a telephone number and can you come in tomorrow at 8:30?" And so it was, he said, "They're switching to the 800 number, so the number is 800-325-3535. And I said, "Well can we do it like 8-oh-oh instead? And he said, "Yeah, either way it's all right." And so at 8:00 the next morning I was driving into New York to go to BBDO and standing there was the entire account people behind me and I'm at the piano doing, [sings] 8-oh-oh-325-3535, which lasted longer than the 13-week promo for the new telephone number.

MR: Were you singing that in your head on the way?

AP: I wrote it on the way in, because everything I wrote the night before was awful.

MR: Oh that's so interesting. Wow. You had to go through the process. The deadline loomed.

AP: Yes it sure did. Many deadlines loomed. But the funniest one really, Pepsi Cola, now they had [sings] come alive, you're in Pepsi generation. Joanie Sommers singing a nice swinging tune. But it was the early '60s and the people that were getting married and having kids really didn't grow up on that music. They grew up on the early Welk stuff. And so I spoke to several music houses about doing it. I wasn't singing a lot of jingles. I didn't really have that jingly sound as a soloist. But I did talk to them about doing some, you know, more rock. And they said well maybe for a couple of chain products but not across the board. And so I happened to meet Scott Muny's brother, anyway introduced us to Hillary Lipsitz who was at BBDO. And Hillary believed that we should be, that their commercials should be more rock-influenced. And so I took "Come Alive" and I did it first with studio people and then did it with the Hondells, the Four Tops, Martha and the Vandellas, and Del Shannon. Anyway they just went on, they were for the youth market on radio. And then came the new campaign. Now when a new campaign is born it's the lyric and what they're selling, how they're going to sell Pepsi. Right? Well the first line that came up, and this time they were not as later came, that they were giving it out to the world and anybody off the street could write it. But this was just given to the four of us: Sid Raymond — I think there were four of us who had done Pepsi commercials. And so we each had to write. Now the very first, and I'll embarrass anybody from BBDO, was

"Pepsi the generous one" which got to be known around the halls of BBDO as "Peppy the generous swan."

MR: Oh that's so interesting, yes, because you can't sing that very well.

AP: No.

MR: The generous one.

AP: I wrote it, and we did a demo on it, and the client didn't like it. Well I hope not. So then they came up with "the taste that beats the others cold." Okay. So we all had to write the taste that beats the others cold. Thank God I won that competition again. And then "Pepsi pours it on" was the next line they came up with. So we all wrote that, did a whole demo on it and so forth, and they couldn't agree. And so between the client and advertising agency, they said, "Well let's put them together and do the whole thing. Write "taste that beats the others cold/Pepsi pours it on." And so I did, and thank God I won that competition too. And that's how I happened to do it with the Four Tops again and —

MR: Well when you say you did it with them, so a chart was written —

AP: I wrote it.

MR: An instrumental chart, you wrote the chart, and then you write the vocal parts and then you have them come in and you sing them the parts or whatever it takes to make this happen.

AP: Yes. We did the tracks first. We were, by then, in at least four track I believe, and so it could — we could do the tracks and they came in from Detroit, the Tops did, and they called and said, "Do you want our arranger to do it" and they said, "No, we have our own arranger" and that was me. So you can imagine when I don't know whether Berry Gordy was there with the Tops and their manager come in and see that there's this little chick out there. And so I did the Tops and whatchacallit Martha, Jackie DeShannon, [scats] what's his name, I can't think. But anyway I'll have to send you the Pepsi history.

MR: Wow. What a story. Were you one of the few women in that level of the business at the time?

AP: I was really the only one that did not only writing but also doing the arranging. And I hadn't taken arranging lesson one. I got — I mean first of all I had done a lot of record dates so I had heard a lot. But — and I got some tips from good arrangers. But the, you know what's his name the big arranger/composer, uh oh, the thing is, who is the "Moon River"—

MR: Oh Henry Mancini.

AP: Henry Mancini's book, which really took the complete mystery out of it because I couldn't imagine how those sounds were made but his book had the piano part and then a CD that had the "now you put it with these strings" "now you put it with four horns and here's how it sounds." Ah. And so, and of course I had the best players in the world. I

mean when I wrote, the first time I wrote a string chart — the first time I wrote a string chart the string players went [scats]. They said, "Anne, you have to put the slur over." So that's how much I knew. But I could, you know, get the ranges of all the instruments and one of the arrangers said, "Just don't do anything to show off how difficult you can write."

MR: Oh that's good advice. Yeah. Was there contractors involved in this that you needed to deal with?

AP: Yeah. Some of them, but pretty much like my first husband and I were in business together at that time and we really knew, I mean for instance the strings, the people that I had known doing demos — not demos but a lot of record dates, David Nadien, who was the concertmaster for Bernstein. That happened while doing it — but you know sometimes I'd ask them to put the string section together. And the horn players I knew actually from the rock-feeling things. There were piano players, mainly ones that worked on demos that knew how to get the feel that I wanted. So it was an interesting time because with the rhythm players, they're the new younger players. Gary Chester was the drummer. You've heard of his name?

MR: Um hum.

AP: And Gary said, "Just 'cause I played strip joints, I know how to play this stuff."

MR: The School of Hard Knocks. Did you have any say in, "All right there's a tenor sax solo, you know four bars here, I want Jerome Richardson." Were you able to say that?

AP: I would hire him. But I mean the thing was, for instance whatchacallit, baritone sax, Artie Kaplan, who did "Locomotion" and I knew Artie from demos and so forth, so if I had that commercial that had that kind of sound in it I would call Artie.

MR: What would make a studio player not get called back?

AP: Not having a pencil. And also questioning things that he could have figured out himself, and taking up time.

MR: I know exactly what you mean. Yes.

AP: There are some of those people.

MR: Yeah you sometimes wonder if they actually knew, but they sort of wanted to put you in your place or something.

AP: Uh huh. There was one of those.

MR: Yeah. Yeah.

AP: Yup. And I didn't call him back.

MR: "Gee why isn't my phone ringing anymore?" Well think about it.

AP: But the wonderful thing was that everybody was such good friends. I mean I remember doing a big thing and we finished a take, I think it was one of the Pepsi things. And it was a big thing. And whoever was in the booth said, "I'll buy that." And from the back of the

percussion section George Devin said, "I'm not selling." And I'll tell you one of the great things, I mean there was so much friend and camaraderie on it. I was doing a session, I contracted the voices for — oh come on, come on, okay I'll get it in a minute, but nevertheless the voices were in the booth and in the connecting booth was the artist who was Sammy Davis Junior. And this was Claus Ogerman, there we are. And Claus had his hands up in the air and I'm in the booth with my hands up ready to cue the singers when Sammy leans out of his booth and grabs my arm and he says, "You see all those little brown spots? Did it ever occur to you that if they got together you'd be colored?" Claus heard, "not a beautiful ooo."

MR: That's terrific. Did you ever work with Joe Wilder?

AP: Oh yes.

MR: Oh what a delightful person he was.

AP: Yes, absolutely. See those were the people that were around and playing record dates, all those greatest.

MR: It's funny, Dick Hyman made a comment at the time playing some of those pop tunes and they would joke about, "Just think, in twenty years people were saying, 'they're playing our song.'" And he says and they were. That's what happened.

AP: Yes. It was funny, Artie Butler — do you know Artie?

MR: Yes I do.

AP: Artie some years ago said, "You know, remember how dumb we used to think some of those songs were? Today they sound like Mozart."

MR: Well yes, I'm fascinated, I love just the arrangements that go into these things. And there's a lot to be learned from that. When you created those commercials a lot of times they were a minute long, sometimes more, sometimes less. But what goes through your head now when you watch television and they fit like three commercials in like in twenty seconds?

AP: Well commercials, a minute and a half, I can't stand it. And there's no music of any sort. I mean here and there they'll use a standard because the person who was selected — that song — it has the same amount of syllables you know.

MR: Yes. How did you price your work at the time? Was there a standard musicians union thing involved?

AP: Not for Creative. Creative was whatever you set it for. It was around $2,500, $3,000 or something like that. And then the union things were what they were. But the Creative was never a union thing or it would have been ridiculously low.

MR: Use that term again? The Creative?

AP: Yeah. I'm talking about writing the song.

MR: Okay.

AP: Because almost everything I did I wrote the song as well.

MR: And was it judged as — simply as all right this is 8 bars, this is 16, or this is a 30-second commercial? Did that play into a pricing.

AP: Not to pricing. No. No in fact I wish I had realized I should have gotten paid for the "Little Blue Flame" for American Gas, which was [scats]. I just did that at the end of the first commercial and kept doing it because I did a lot of those and those were 30s, 60s, and 90s. And there were some beautiful stuff. But after years went by I said you know I should have gotten some money for that "Blue Flame."

MR: Wow. How did you — last question about this, did you have to do anything extraordinary in the beginning to get the respect of the studio musicians?

AP: No. They just respected what I did and they played it and nobody — I mean the one musician that I remember that kept making corrections, and I didn't use again. But there was never anybody like that. I mean all of the people that were in it, we enjoyed each other, we had a good time together, and I know that they respected me.

MR: I suspect that many of those players were happy to be off the road, still playing well-conceived music and being able to go home at night.

AP: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

AP: Yup. I think so. There were Seldon Powell — I just remember so many of them that were on these sessions because they were in New York now and they could read and they, you know, because on a record date it was three hours and you could do four sides and you usually did three or four. And you know they were all good musicians and had a good time being there. And their scale was their scale, which was the union scale for — I mean I know singers were like 60 bucks for a record session, and it did go up and up you know but it was a —

MR: What's the state of the musicians union now? Are you aware of it?

AP: Well I mean the thing is that so much has been done in synthesizers and those — I don't know if anybody writes anything real anymore. I mean have you listened?

MR: Yeah.

AP: I heard —

MR: Your timing was good then.

AP: Oh it was the best. Because there was work for singers, it was really — one, if you could read — you had to read — and that's why when I was teaching at NYU and I started a class 'cause these kids are paying 60 grand a year, probably 80 now, and they're not learning to read music and they're music majors. Come on. And so I started a class for sight reading for singers, and another one for repertoire, 'cause another one of the problems was they didn't know, you know, standards. And I opened that to musicians as

well. Well they didn't come. And a lot of the musicians, the young musicians, don't know any standards. They go back to, you know — I think they're finding out that they have to now, but there was a long period —

MR: Uh huh. They're not going to get called for a club date and play their own music.

AP: No. Exactly.

MR: Hey come on down and bring your original tunes.

AP: Everybody can't wait to hear them.

MR: One last thing with this. Chico Hamilton talked about, you know he did this for 15 or 20 years, and he — this is a quote from him. He says, "I started in '66 until the 80s maybe. I learned how to drink in the daytime, the three martini lunch, and how to schmooze. I made a lot of dough but what good is the dough when you kind of lose something." So do you know, what is that something that he would have felt?

AP: I certainly know it about guys that went into Broadway. Because Broadway gig was like the bottom of the barrel during that time when there were record dates and so forth. And then when those dates began to go away and people began to take Broadway jobs they lost something and they talked about losing that something. And you know I was fortunate because I was writing most of what I did. I mean I did the first record dates, of course all record dates were wonderful, but I was working with Charlie Calello who did all the Four Seasons stuff you know, and other stuff, and the record dates were well written, were good stuff and fun. And as a rhythm player, I mean Gary Chester was the main one and there were others, and the guitar players changed to the younger guys. Have you heard, do you know Al Gorgoni?

MR: What's the name?

AP: Al Gorgoni.

MR: No.

AP: He's one, he's a wonderful guitar player, classical as well as, you know. But he was one of the young guys that I met at Associated, and then when I started doing commercials then he was one of the main ones I called you know, because they could get that feel.

MR: Yeah. It's important to know in those situations what to leave out too, as an arranger.

AP: Oh yeah.

MR: Right? Stepping on the vocals and —

AP: Absolutely. In fact one of the things that they don't teach anywhere is how to be an accompanist to a pianist, as a pianist, how to accompany a singer. Because that's an art in itself. And a lot of the young guys are not learning that at all and they're all over the place. It was a story from NYU but they gave me somebody that my singer said, "I could sing that at my lesson but I can't sing —" I said no wonder, I couldn't come in on that intro in a million years because it was just all over the place and he's playing filler and

now come on, you're supposed to make that singer — lift her up, make it wonderful. And there are very few young — Fred Hersch is one that has really taken the place of the Mike Renzis of the world. But there are not many guys around that really accompany well and they certainly don't teach it in the schools.

MR: At the end of this article I have from you, you used the word "joy" a lot. And you just made me think of it because a good accompanist has to be joyful in what they do. That has to bring them joy that they are assisting a musical performance.

AP: Absolutely. You know and there are wonderful ones that do exactly that. And if you don't feel that joy, if it's — see a lot of pianists are there to show themselves off and so accompanying a singer is a dumb gig. That's a foolish idea.

MR: I totally agree. So briefly "Bending Towards the Light" is in — how many years now?

AP: This will be the 40th if I do it this year.

MR: If you do it this year.

AP: It's been done — last year it was the first time in Tucson, it's been done for 30 years in Greensboro, North Carolina, they do it every single year. And Bozeman, Montana they did it. But the problem is that unless you can prove to a publisher — I was with Schirmer for the first ten years, and the only performances that came through Schirmer were ones that I found. And then I took it back, and now I have shipped it myself. But unless you can get it on television — and we did have a wonderful producer who is a major producer who did it for PBS and she presented it to them. And we had everybody — Dave Brubeck, Lionel Hampton, Tito Puente, you name it. And the place to do it — we were going to do it in October at the Apollo so it could be on the air, and they said yes to it. However you'll have to bring it to us ready for air. You know what that means?

MR: It means a lot of money.

AP: It means a hell of a lot of money. At that point it was $350,000 was the budget. And that's nowhere near what it would be today. And so the publishers, now Samuel French did publish a childrens' show, *The Great Gray Ghost of Old Spook Lane*. Anyway I went to talk to them recently and I couldn't find them, because they have now been bought by Concord Theatricals. Concord Theatricals is another big — it was Concord Records the jazz label originally, of California. But it has grown and it now owns Andrew Lloyd Weber, Bernstein — or whatchacalit — Hammerstein — Rogers & Hammerstein, all of that they license. And so to license it they want to know that it's going to sell like crazy the first year. Well if it's not on television then nobody knows what it is. So that's where I am after all this time, because it's been done in about 40, 50 cities. And every place it's been done by their local people.

MR: Like Utica, New York.

AP: Well in New York it's done —

MR: In Utica here, we did it.

AP: Oh that's right. You're in Utica.

MR: Yes. Outside Utica.

AP: That's right.

MR: Yes I saw it, you probably were there.

AP: I was, yes.

MR: It's a wonderful production. I'm guessing that you have significant powers of persuasion.

AP: Not with big corporations.

MR: Yes right. There is a limit to that. But I envision the whole idea and then approaching these musicians and you did well.

AP: Well it's very funny because that first year nobody knew what it was you know. I mean I got — the very first year I did it I had Grady Tate, Tommy Flanagan, George Mraz — but a good band and so forth. And they all did it. The second year there's a whole story in between that that you don't want to hear. Nevertheless the second year I remember calling Doc Cheatham was a — one of the three kings. Now all I had money for was to rehearse in the afternoon. I had a band rehearsal before and then the day of the show we run the show and then do the show. So it was like 3:00 in the afternoon and we were supposed to be running the show. And — what's his name —

MR: Doc?

AP: Wasn't there. And I called him up and he said, "Oh I'm just having my lunch." He said "you know I'm going to play a couple of Christmas songs, right?" I said, "No." Because he had no concept of this being a show and it's quite different when you're working with musicians and you want them to come forward here and, you know. But we have a director now, Beth Ann Kennedy, who really can connect. The first couple of directors didn't really connect with the musicians as well. But they love it now and, you know, I had this year, in New York I had Ron Carter. And Ron as a special guest. Now he played it in the very second show and he never forgot it. Because every time I'd see him somewhere he'd say, "Oh that was so great" and so forth. But I hadn't had him in the band since. But this time I decided to ask him to be a special guest, which is after the whole play itself and then it goes into the celebration of "Deck the Halls" when all these different people come out and play. And that's where I was going to put him. And he said, "Well who's your bass player?" I said, "Dean Johnson." He said, "Can I use his bass?" And I said, "Yeah, I'll call him, I don't think he'll have a problem with that." And I will tell you, it was utter magic. Because it was during the finale, it was right after the tap dancers so it was all this — it was big. And then absolute silence and he went down and Dean handed him his bass, and there was wood floors for one thing. The sound was extraordinary. And utter silence from the audience, because they really couldn't believe

who they were seeing and hearing. And it was just gorgeous. And the next day I got a call from him, he said, "What's your address I want to send you something." And in it was his book that's the Smithsonian interviews. It's a gorgeous book, color and so forth. With a good add: To Anne, thank you, Ron. He's thanking me. So that's how much the musicians love it.

MR: It's interesting you said that about sort of corralling the musicians and said, "Okay after this number then you have to go over here." And I had that experience doing a show with a singer, a Billie Holiday show, and you know she would say, "After this thing you say this and then I'll say this." And I was going, "What do you mean?" It's theater.

AP: Yes. We could never get Phil Woods to come forward enough. We let him wear his hat as a crown but —

MR: I'll be darned. Well you are just — have accomplished so much in your lifetime and — you still have projects going on for the future?

AP: Well I got a nice thing, you know I belong to the women's New York Womens' Music Composers thing. And every once in a while there'll be something that a performer is looking for, and there was a piano thing that a pianist wanted. Well okay, I'll send the thing in. And it was a rag that I wrote for a play with music called "Pan Handle" many years ago. Anyway I love rag, but I could never do anything with it. It's a piano rag. Although one of the performers in the show ran up when I played it at the first rehearsal, he said, "What is that?" I said, "I wrote it." He said, "Oh my God I thought it was Scott Joplin and it's disappeared or something" which was the nicest thing he could say. Anyway I just got a thing from a woman who is a pianist who is doing a concert and she's playing my rag in that concert at upper Americas on the nineteenth. And then I've been doing, you know, my birthday thing. I did a whole — I did a short show at a senior residence, which is telling my story. And I made it bigger for the birthday party. And that got sold out. And so many people have wanted to see it again. So I have a real interesting one-woman, about an hour fifteen, hour and a half show that really goes through my life of music and covers a lot of ground.

MR: I'll bet. And I can see many moments where people are going, "Oh, I remember that, you wrote that?"

AP: Yeah. We did demos for Ellie.

MR: Wow.

AP: I have to tell you a funny thing. When they did a show on "Leader of the Pack" after it was a big hit, and I took my kids when they were in middle school, to see it, because Ellie Greenwich was starring in it and so forth. And I introduced her to Ellie and Ellie looked at them and said, "I am your prenatal influence." Because I had three kids through all of this.

MR: Wow. Well this has been great pleasure and thank you very much for joining me today.

AP: Well thank you for having me.

MR: And maybe we'll get to meet sometime in some little dive in New York City. Who knows?

AP: Who knows? If I do my story again at Pangea, I'll let you know.

MR: All right. Well I'll pause this and then we'll say our good-byes and thanks again.

AP: Okay.